

Cārvāka — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Nine owned PYQs, one routed mirror, six original models

Contains every directly owned verified PYQ through 2026, the explicitly routed Nyāya-owned mirror question, and all six formal original solved models. Timed model answers retain the exact 150–200 / 250–300 / 340–400 word bands.

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Verified ownership summary

Status	Questions
Primary-owned and solved	2018 Q8(b); 2019 Q5(c), Q6(c); 2020 Q6(b), Q7(c); 2021 Q5(e); 2024 Q5(a), Q6(a); 2025 Q5(a)
Supporting routed and solved	2022 Q7(c), primary owner Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika
2026	No direct Cārvāka question in the verified ledger

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Practice status and source discipline — read once, applies to every solution below

Every model answer here is independent learner practice and is **never** an official UPSC key. Because the *Bṛhaspati-sūtra* is lost and the doctrine is reconstructed chiefly from hostile or refutational witnesses, doctrinal claims are framed as the standard Cārvāka reconstruction, and Jayarāśi Bhaṭṭa is used only as a contested sceptical limit-case rather than as a plain representative of that standard position. Question wording is reproduced exactly as printed in the official papers.

Answer-length convention used throughout this package. UPSC Philosophy Paper I parts are written longer than General Studies answers. The working bands are **10 marks — about 150 to 200 words**, **15 marks — about 250 to 300 words**, and **20 marks — about 340 to 400 words**. Each solution prints the timed answer first; where a paragraph is marked *Depth refinement*, it is a teaching addendum that sits **outside** the timed word count.

Coverage: nine directly owned Cārvāka PYQs from 2018 to 2025, one supporting routed 2022 question owned by Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika, and six original solved Mains models — two each at 10, 15 and 20 marks.

2018 · Q8(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is Cārvāka rejection of inference acceptable to the other systems of Indian philosophy? If not, why? Do you think the views of other systems to be justified? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Three-limbed: a factual survey, an explanatory account, and an evaluative judgement in the candidate's own voice
Limb 1	Is it accepted? — a cross-school survey; the answer is overwhelmingly no
Limb 2	If not, why not? — the <i>reasons</i> , school by school, not a single generic reason

Element	Requirement
Limb 3	Are they justified? — the candidate's graded verdict, with reasons
Scope boundary	Stay on inference ; do not drift into Cārvāka ethics or the ritual polemic
Ideal thesis	The other systems are justified against the strong thesis, but the Cārvāka's residual point — that finite observation cannot entail an unrestricted universal — survives, and Nyāya concedes it by shifting from certainty to warrant
Non-negotiables	<i>Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)</i> ; the three doors; <i>hidden limiting condition (upādhi)</i> ; at least three named schools with their distinct reasons; the self-refutation charge; a criterion-named verdict

Independent model answer

The Cārvāka holds that *inference (anumāna)* is not a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*, because *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* cannot be secured: not by perception, since all cases past, present and future are never surveyed; not by inference, which yields a *petitio principii*; and not by testimony, whose own validity is inferred — and which, if it grounded inference, would mean "no one could infer anything by himself". *Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* deepens this: the wet-fuel condition shows that unconditionality can never be perceptually certified.

No system accepts this. Nyāya replies that *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* is built by *anvaya-vyatireka*, elimination of suspected *upādhis*, *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* and *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*, and that *parāmarśa* — the mark cognised as qualified by concomitance — means no "leap" occurs. Sāṃkhya must reject it, since *primordial material nature (prakṛti)* and *conscious witness (puruṣa)* are established only inferentially. Mīmāṃsā must, since injunction and *apūrva* presuppose it. Buddhism, through Dignāga and Dharmakīrti, constructs an entire logic, and the *Tattvasaṅgraha* attacks Cārvāka's naïve perceptualism directly. Jainism needs inference for *matī* and *śruta*. Advaita alone partly agrees, but denies **ultimate** validity to perception as well — a level-distinction, as Sharma observes, "unknown to the Cārvāka".

Are they justified? Largely yes. The universal denial of inference is itself a universal; other minds and ideas are never perceived; Sharma is right that "the Cārvāka can understand others only through inference".

⚠ **Verdict:** they are justified against the strong thesis but not entitled to complacency, since Nyāya answers only by replacing omniscient certainty with disciplined warrant — a substitution that concedes the Cārvāka's logical point while denying his epistemological conclusion.

Depth refinement. The dispute is therefore not between reason and anti-reason. It concerns whether *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* means indefeasible truth or responsibly corrigible warrant. Nyāya is strongest by the latter criterion; Cārvāka survives as a challenge to unrestricted universals.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2018 Q8(b): all three limbs must be visibly answered: the cross-school survey, the school-specific reasons, and the candidate's own graded verdict. A single generic reason for all schools halves the marks.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: thesis and three doors in four lines; four schools with distinct reasons; the self-refutation charge in two lines; a criterion-named verdict.

- **Structure:** state the Cārvāka thesis with its argument → survey the schools with **distinct** reasons → the self-refutation charge → the candidate's graded verdict. All three limbs must be visibly answered.
- **Doctrine:** *invariable concomitance (vyāpti), hidden limiting condition (upādhi), petitio principii, anvaya-vyatireka, hypothetical reasoning (tarka), parāmarśa, sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa.*
- **Argument:** the three doors must appear as three, not as a vague "cannot be proved".
- **Distinction:** rejection of inference as *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* versus rejection of practical inference — flag it, or the answer looks naïve.
- **Comparison:** at least four schools with school-specific reasons. A generic "all schools accept inference" earns half the marks.
- **Criticism:** self-refutation stated as steps, plus Sharma's point that thoughts and other minds are never perceived.

2019 · Q5(c) · 10 marks

Question: Are the Cārvākas consistent when they hold that inference is not a source of knowledge? Discuss.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Discuss with an explicit verdict on consistency — a yes/no question that requires a qualified answer
Core issue	Whether the denial of inference can be stated and defended without using inference
Scope boundary	This is about internal coherence , not about whether inference is in fact valid
Ideal thesis	Inconsistent on the strong reading; consistent on the softened reading — but the softened reading is a much weaker doctrine
Non-negotiables	The charge reconstructed as steps; at least two of the three replies; the point that other minds and ideas are never perceived; a graded verdict

Independent model answer

The charge. The Cārvāka asserts that no inference is a valid source of knowledge. That assertion is a **universal**, quantifying over all inferential acts; no universal is given in any single perception. So it is either itself inferential — and self-defeating — or it fails its own standard. Sharma presses further: thoughts and ideas "cannot be perceived; they can only be inferred", so the Cārvāka "can understand others only through inference and make others understand him only through inference".

The replies. ⚠ Three are available. (i) *Vitaṇḍā*: the Cārvāka advances no thesis, only destroys the opponent's claim to certainty — but he does assert four elements and a body-self, so this cannot be global. (ii) The **softened thesis**: he denies not inference itself but its capacity to yield **apodictic certainty**,

especially about the transcendent. (iii) The **level-distinction**: concede *vyāvahārika* validity, deny the *pāramārthika* — though Sharma notes this distinction is "unknown to the Cārvāka".

⚠️ **Verdict**: inconsistent as an unrestricted denial; consistent as a fallibilist warning. The Cārvāka may be **radical or consistent, but not both**.

Depth refinement. A practical concession needs an epistemic status: if successful worldly inference is knowledge, the absolute thesis contracts; if it is only expectation, Cārvāka must explain why rational action may trust what philosophy disqualifies.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q5(c): the question is about internal coherence, not about whether inference is valid. Reconstruct the charge as numbered steps, then supply at least two of the three replies before judging.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: the charge in three steps; two replies; one line on other minds; a verdict that separates the radical from the consistent reading.

- **Structure**: state the charge as numbered steps → give the replies → deliver the verdict. Do not narrate the *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*) argument at length; the question presupposes it.
- **Doctrine**: the exact form of the thesis being tested — "no inference is a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*)" — and its universality.
- **Argument**: the step from "universal claim" to "not perceptually given" must be explicit.
- **Distinction**: *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*)-status versus practical usability; strong versus softened formulation.
- **Technical terms**: *vitaṇḍā*, *vyāvahārika* / *pāramārthika*, *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*).
- **Criticism**: the other-minds point is the sharpest form of the charge and is usually omitted.

2019 · Q6(c) · 15 marks

Question: What is wrong according to the Cārvākas with the following argument? All men are mortal. Socrates is a man. Therefore, Socrates is mortal. Justify your answer with arguments.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	Diagnose a specific argument, then justify the diagnosis — application, not recitation
Core issue	Whether the candidate attacks the right thing: the major premise , not the form
Scope boundary	Use the smoke-and-fire material only as illustration; the syllogism itself must stay in focus
Ideal thesis	The syllogism is valid but epistemically empty — it transmits a certainty in the major premise that was never independently acquired

Element	Requirement
Non-negotiables	Explicit refusal to attack validity; the major premise identified as <i>invariable concomitance (vyāpti)</i> ; the three doors applied to "All men are mortal"; <i>petitio principii</i> ; <i>hidden limiting condition (upādhi)</i> ; one line of self-critical balance

Independent model answer

The Cārvāka objection is **not** that the argument is formally invalid. If the premises hold, the conclusion follows; the Cārvāka concedes this and attacks elsewhere.

The target is the **major premise**, "All men are mortal", which functions exactly as *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* does in Indian inference: an invariable, exceptionless concomitance between man-ness and mortality. How is such a universal known?

Not by perception. No one has perceived all men. Chatterjee and Datta press the point: we cannot perceive even all present cases, "to speak nothing of those which existed in the past or will exist in the future." Nor does relocating the relation among class-characters help: "it is not possible even to know by perception what 'smokeness' ... is, because we do not perceive all cases of smoke", and a relation between universals does not license an inference about **this** particular.

Not by inference. Establishing the universal inferentially requires a further universal — *petitio principii*, or an endless regress.

Not by testimony. Testimony's validity is itself inferred; and if inference depended on testimony, "no one could infer anything by himself."

Hence, in Sharma's formulation, the syllogism is an **argument in a circle**: the conclusion "Socrates is mortal" is already contained in "All men are mortal". Deduction merely extracts what induction never established. *Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* deepens the charge: perhaps what is genuinely invariable is not man-ness with mortality but organic embodiment under conditions never fully surveyed.

⚠ **Verdict:** the syllogism is valid but epistemically empty. The charge is a serious one about induction — though the Cārvāka must still explain how his own universal denial of inference is known.

Depth refinement. This diagnosis anticipates the problem of induction without making Cārvāka a modern empiricist. Its precise claim is not that deduction fails formally, but that deduction cannot manufacture warrant absent from its universal premise.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2019 Q6(c): refuse the temptation to attack validity. Concede the form at once, identify the major premise as an invariable concomitance, then apply the three doors to 'All men are mortal'.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: two lines conceding form; the major premise identified; three doors applied to the actual premise; the hidden condition; one line of self-critical balance.

- **Structure:** disclaim the attack on validity → identify the major premise as *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*) → run the three doors **on this premise** → *petitio principii* → *hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*) → verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*), *sāmānya* / class-character, *hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*), *petitio principii*.
- **Argument:** the three doors must be applied to "All men are mortal" specifically, not narrated abstractly about smoke.
- **Distinction:** validity versus soundness; deduction's circularity versus induction's insecurity, and the fact that each is cured only by the other.
- **Technical terms:** major premise as *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*); *sādhya* and *hetu*; *inference* (*anumāna*) and *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*).
- **Comparison:** one line noting that Nyāya would answer with *anvaya-vyatireka*, *hypothetical reasoning* (*tarka*) and *parāmarśa*.

2020 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: Critically evaluate Cārvākas' rejection of Ākāśa as one of the elements of reality and examine their criticism of transmigration of Soul.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically evaluate and examine</i> — two tasks, both requiring two-sided assessment
Core issue	That both rejections are the same argument applied twice , once to cosmology and once to soteriology
Scope boundary	Two halves, roughly balanced; do not let <i>ākāśa</i> consume the answer
Ideal thesis	The rejections are impeccably consistent with the epistemology, and are therefore exactly as strong — and as vulnerable — as that epistemology
Non-negotiables	The Vaiśeṣika sound-to- <i>ākāśa</i> inference named and refused; the four requirements of transmigration each cut; at least two objections with replies; a criterion-named verdict

Independent model answer

Ākāśa. ✓ Most Indian schools admit five elements; Cārvāka admits four — earth, water, fire and air. The reason is exact: *ākāśa* "is not perceived but **inferred**" (Sharma). The Vaiśeṣika reaches it by argument — sound is a quality; qualities inhere in substances; sound belongs to no other admitted substance; therefore *ākāśa* exists as its substrate. Since inference is not a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*), that route is closed.

⚠ **Critical evaluation.** The rejection is consistent and economical, and it correctly identifies that *ākāśa* is a **theoretical posit**, not a datum. But it carries a cost: the Cārvāka accepts the four elements *as substances*, so he cannot refuse the substance–quality scheme for sound alone without argument. His strongest line is therefore to naturalise sound as a modification of perceptible air — a naturalising rather than a merely sceptical move.

Transmigration. ✅ Transmigration requires (a) a self distinct from the body, (b) its survival after death, (c) a carrier of moral desert, and (d) knowledge that these obtain. Cārvāka cuts each: *conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)* makes the self the living body — *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ*; "death of the body means the end of the individual"; *action and moral consequence (karma)* and *adr̥ṣṭa* are unperceived; and only scripture or inference could supply the knowledge.

⚠️ **Examination.** Strengths: consistency, economy, and the exposure of unfalsifiable postulates. Weaknesses: Sharma shows that dependence is not production — "the eye cannot see in darkness ... yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight"; the argument slides from "unestablished" to "unreal"; and, as Sharma adds, the soul's non-existence "too cannot be demonstrated".

⚠️ **Verdict:** one epistemic cut, applied twice — and its force is exactly the force of that cut.

Depth refinement. The burden of proof remains crucial: Cārvāka may show that the opponent has not established *ākāśa* or transmigration, but the stronger claim of non-existence needs a bridge from epistemic absence to ontological absence.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2020 Q6(b): the question has two limbs and both must be evaluated critically, not merely reported. Keep the rejection of ether and the criticism of transmigration on the same single criterion.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the criterion in two lines; the ether limb; the transmigration limb; one Nyāya or Vedāntic objection with a reply; a graded verdict.

- **Structure:** two clearly signposted halves, each with exposition and evaluation; a unifying final sentence.
- **Doctrine:** four *bhūtas*; the Vaiśeṣika sound-substrate inference; *conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)*; *adr̥ṣṭa*.
- **Argument:** the four requirements of transmigration, each explicitly cut.
- **Distinction:** rejecting *ākāśa* as an entity versus denying that sound is heard; "unestablished" versus "unreal".
- **Technical terms:** *ākāśa*, *bhūta*, *adr̥ṣṭa*, *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ*, *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*.
- **Criticism:** at least two — the instrument objection and the unestablished/unreal slide; ideally Sharma's symmetry point too.

2020 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: Explain the differences of conception of Reality between Cārvāka and Jainism.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Explain the differences</i> — a sustained axis-by-axis comparison, not two mini-essays
Core issue	Conceptions of reality : what exists, how it is known, and how change and persistence are accommodated

Element	Requirement
Scope boundary	Metaphysics and its epistemology; ethics only if it illuminates the ontology
Ideal thesis	The deepest difference is not materialism versus spiritualism but the number of standpoints each admits — Jainism multiplies both entities and viewpoints; Cārvāka admits one of each
Non-negotiables	<i>Means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)</i> ; the definition of <i>sat</i> ; four <i>bhūtas</i> versus six <i>dravyas</i> ; <i>ākāśa</i> ; soul and consciousness; <i>anekāntavāda</i> and <i>syādvāda</i> ; action and moral consequence (karma); liberation; and the shared <i>Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)</i> ground

Independent model answer

Epistemic root. ✓ Cārvāka admits one *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*, *perception (pratyakṣa)*. Jainism admits a fivefold knowledge — *mati*, *śruta*, *avadhi*, *manaḥparyāya*, *kevala* — and hence inference. Every later divergence follows from this.

Definition of the real. ✓ For Jainism, *sat* is **utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya** — origination, decay and persistence together; the gold that becomes bracelet and then ring persists as *dravya* while its *paryāyas* change. Cārvāka has no such analysis: elements are eternal, combinations transient, and that is all.

Constituents. ✓ Four *bhūtas* for Cārvāka; **six dravyas** for Jainism — *individual self (jīva)*, *pudgala*, *dharma*, *adharma*, *ākāśa*, *kāla*. *Ākāśa* is rejected by the Cārvāka as inferred; for Jainism it is a distinct substance providing accommodation.

Soul and consciousness. ✓ Cārvāka: no *individual self (jīva)*; the self is the living body, and consciousness an emergent by-product. Jainism: infinitely many *individual self (jīvas)*, with consciousness their **inseparable essence** — expressly denying, as the sources put it, the Cārvāka view that it is "a mere accidental property, arising only under some conditions".

Standpoint. ✓ Jainism's **anekāntavāda**, with *nayavāda* and *syādvāda*, holds reality many-faced and every judgement conditioned. Cārvāka admits a single standpoint and no level-distinction at all.

Action and moral consequence (karma) and liberation. ✓ Jainism: action and moral consequence (karma) as **subtle matter** adhering to the *individual self (jīva)*, *bhāvabandha* and *dravyabandha*, with *liberation (mokṣa)* through the three jewels and *kevala-jñāna*. Cārvāka: no action and moral consequence (karma), and *marāṇam eva apavargaḥ*.

⚠ **Verdict.** Their agreement is instructive: both are *Veda-rejecting school (nāstika)*, both realists about the perceptible world, both reject a creator. The divergence is over standpoints and substances — which is why Jainism can hold change and persistence together while Cārvāka can only assert them side by side.

Depth refinement. Jainism buys explanatory articulation through ontological plurality; Cārvāka buys economy through restriction. Jainism therefore wins on change-and-persistence, while Cārvāka preserves the question of evidential cost.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2020 Q7(c): argue the contrast across four axes — means of knowledge, substance, self and liberation — instead of writing 'materialism versus spiritualism', which is the answer the examiner expects to reject.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: define each conception in two lines; four contrast axes with named doctrine; one point of contact; a verdict on which conception is better supported and by what standard.

- **Structure:** named axes, each carrying both positions in the same sentence or row; then the unifying thesis; then the shared ground.
- **Doctrine:** *utpāda-vyaya-dhrauvya*; six *dravyas*; constituent quality (*guṇa*) and *paryāya*; *anekānta*, *naya*, *syādvāda*; four *bhūtas*.
- **Argument:** show that the metaphysical divergence is *generated* by the epistemic divergence.
- **Distinction:** Jaina *dharma* and *adharma* are **media of motion and rest**, not merit and demerit — a classic trap.
- **Technical terms:** *sat*, *dravya*, *individual self (jīva)*, *pudgala*, *bhūta*, *kevala-jñāna*, *bhāvabandha* and *dravyabandha*.
- **Comparison:** at least seven axes; fewer looks thin at 15 marks.

2021 · Q5(e) · 10 marks

Question: Comment on the bearing of Cārvāka epistemology on the rejection of transcendental entities by them.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Comment on the bearing</i> — the examiner wants the derivation , not two lists
Core issue	That a single epistemic premise severs every transcendent entity at once
Scope boundary	Do not narrate the <i>invariable concomitance (vyāpti)</i> argument at length; compress it and spend the words on the derivation
Ideal thesis	Cārvāka ontology is the exact ontological shadow of its epistemology, so the denials are consequences and not separate acts of unbelief
Non-negotiables	The compressed epistemic argument; the bridging principle named as a presupposition; at least five entities derived; one line of evaluation

Independent model answer

For Cārvāka, ontology is the shadow cast by epistemology. Perception alone is a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*: inference (*anumāna*) fails because *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* is established neither by perception (all cases are never surveyed), nor by inference (*petitio principii*), nor by testimony (whose own validity is inferred); *verbal testimony (śabda)* fails because words certify only that something was said. Chatterjee and Datta accordingly state that the Cārvāka theory of reality "**follows from**" this epistemological conclusion.

The **bearing** is systematic. The bridging principle — ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇas*) — is then applied without exception. *Ākāśa* falls, being inferred from sound. *Enduring self* (*ātman*) falls, never being perceived apart from the living body. *Lord* (*Īśvara*) falls, being reached only by design-inference while *svabhāva* discharges the explanatory work. *Action and moral consequence* (*karma*), *adṛṣṭa*, rebirth, *svarga* and *liberation* (*mokṣa*) fall as unseen forces or post-mortem states no perception could present. Vedic authority falls with *verbal testimony* (*śabda*), and ritual loses its rationale with it.

⚠ **Comment:** the derivation is impeccably consistent; its cost is that the whole ontology stands or falls with the rejection of inference.

Depth refinement. The denials are not object-level duplicates: some reject theoretical substrates, some moral mechanisms, and some authoritative testimony. Their unity lies in one evidential filter rather than one identical argument.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2021 Q5(e): the directive is *comment on the bearing*, so the epistemology must be shown doing the work. Derive at least three denials from the single criterion rather than listing them.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: state the criterion; derive three denials from it in one movement; one objection; a one-sentence verdict on the derivation, not on materialism in general.

- **Structure:** epistemology compressed into one paragraph → the bridging principle → the derivation, entity by entity → one evaluative line.
- **Doctrine:** *pratyakṣaika-pramāṇavāda*, the bridging principle; *explanation through natural properties* (*svabhāvavāda*).
- **Argument:** the derivation must read as a *consequence*, with connectives such as "hence", "therefore", "with it".
- **Distinction:** the bridging principle is a **presupposition**, not a theorem — an opponent could accept the epistemology and still hold that reality exceeds knowledge.
- **Technical terms:** *ākāśa*, *enduring self* (*ātman*), *Lord* (*Īśvara*), *action and moral consequence* (*karma*), *adṛṣṭa*, *svarga*, *liberation* (*mokṣa*), *verbal testimony* (*śabda*).
- **Comparison:** if space allows, one clause noting that Sāṃkhya and Mīmāṃsā are also non-theistic but keep *action and moral consequence* (*karma*) and rebirth, because their epistemology admits inference.

2024 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: Do you think Cārvāka's philosophy is positivistic in nature? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	An explicit personal verdict with reasons and justifications — a graded answer, never a flat yes or no

Element	Requirement
Core issue	Whether an empiricist criterion and anti-metaphysical temper suffice for the label, given that Cārvāka rejects inference
Scope boundary	Comparative epistemology and method; do not turn it into a history of logical positivism
Ideal thesis	Positivistic in spirit , not in method ; "radical empiricism" is the safer label
Non-negotiables	The evidential point that the textbooks themselves apply the word; at least three points for and three against; the inference divergence; a named alternative label

Independent model answer

⚠️ Yes in spirit, no in method.

The case for. ✅ The label is not imported by the examiner: Chatterjee and Datta write that the Cārvāka theory "may also be called **positivism**, because it believes only in **positive facts or observable phenomena**", and compare its view of inference to that of "the pragmatists and logical positivists". Cārvāka restricts the knowable to what perception presents; rejects God, soul, *action and moral consequence (karma)* and heaven as unwarranted; refuses scriptural authority; grounds value in this-worldly pleasure and pain; and even adopts a quasi-verificationist register, since questions about rebirth and heaven are said to become "**meaningless**".

The case against. ⚠️ Positivism is built on **inference** — science is systematised inference — which Cārvāka denies *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*-status. Positivism admits unobservables that earn their explanatory keep; Cārvāka refuses them. Positivism offers a constructive programme with formal and semantic tools; Cārvāka offers a polemical minimalism. Comte's law of three stages and sociology have no Indian counterpart.

⚠️ **Verdict:** an illuminating analogy, not a historical identity. **Radical empiricism** or **naturalistic materialism** is the more accurate description. The paradox is that Cārvāka reaches a materialist conclusion by an **anti-inferential** route.

Depth refinement. The comparison is heuristic, not genealogical. Cārvāka resembles positivism in policing metaphysical admission but differs because its anti-inferentialism weakens the law-governed science that later positivisms elevate.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q5(a): a flat yes or a flat no both lose marks. Establish that the label is already used in the standard expositions, give the case for it, then the decisive disanalogy about inference.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: three movements — the label is not imported, the case for it, the case against it — and a verdict that accepts the empiricist temper while refusing the identification.

- **Structure:** verdict first → case for → case against → refined label. A graded verdict announced early controls the whole answer.

- **Doctrine:** the textbook's own use of the word "positivism", with its stated reason — this is the strongest single evidential move available.
- **Argument:** the inference divergence must be identified as the **decisive** disanalogy, not listed among equals.
- **Distinction:** spirit versus method; empiricism versus positivism; verificationism versus mere anti-metaphysics.
- **Technical terms:** *perception (pratyakṣa)*, *inference (anumāna)*, *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*, *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)*, verification, unobservables.
- **Comparison:** at least one named Western reference point — Comte or Ayer — used precisely.

2024 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: Differentiate between the Cārvākas' refutation of self as a transcendental category and the Buddhist rejection of ātmā.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Differentiate</i> — sustained contrast on named axes; separate descriptions will not do
Core issue	That two denials of <i>enduring self (ātman)</i> can be philosophically opposite in target, ground, aftermath and metaphysical price
Scope boundary	The self; bring in action and moral consequence (karma), rebirth and liberation only as consequences of the two denials
Ideal thesis	Cārvāka relocates the self into matter; Buddhism dissolves it into process. Substance retained versus substance abolished
Non-negotiables	<i>Conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)</i> with its formula; the five <i>skandhas</i> ; <i>santāna</i> ; the epistemic versus ontological-soteriological grounds; the point that <i>rūpa</i> is itself a <i>skandha</i> ; the divergent aftermaths

Independent model answer

Both schools reject the *enduring self (ātman)* of Nyāya and Vedānta, but the rejections are not species of one genus.

Cārvāka: relocation. ✓ The doctrine is *conscious body as self (dehātmavāda)* — *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ*, the person is the body qualified by consciousness. The **ground is epistemological**: perception alone is a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*, and "the non-material soul is never perceived". The positive argument is drawn from ordinary speech: we say "I am fat", "I am lame", "I am blind", and if the "I" were distinct from the body these would be meaningless. Consciousness is admitted, but as an **emergent by-product** of the organised elements — as the betel leaf, lime and nut together yield a redness none possesses, and as molasses becomes intoxicant on fermenting. Since no self survives the body's dissolution, "death of the body means the end of the individual"; *action and moral consequence (karma)*, rebirth, *svarga* and *liberation (mokṣa)* all lapse, and *marāṇam eva apavargaḥ*.

Buddhism: dissolution. ✓ *Anātman* denies not the transcendence but the **substantiality** of the self. The person is analysed into five *skandhas* — *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saṃjñā*, *saṃskāra*, *viññāna* — with no owner behind them; "chariot" names an arrangement of parts, and so does "person". The **ground is ontological and soteriological**: *pratītyasamutpāda* and *kṣaṇikavāda* leave no room for a permanent entity, and belief in a self generates craving and suffering. Continuity is preserved by *santāna*, the causal stream, with *pratisandhāna* and, in *Yogācāra*, *ālaya-viññāna* bearing *bījas*. Hence action and moral consequence (karma) and rebirth survive **without** a self, and *cessation of conditioned suffering* (*nirvāṇa*) remains the goal.

⚠ **The four differentiating theses.** (i) **Targets** differ: Cārvāka substitutes a material self, whereas Buddhism denies substantiality of any kind — and since *rūpa* is itself one of the *skandhas*, Buddhist analysis refutes the Cārvāka body-self **by name**. (ii) **Grounds** differ: epistemic versus ontological-soteriological. (iii) **Aftermaths** differ: Cārvāka terminates the moral narrative at death; Buddhism is engineered precisely to continue it. (iv) **Prices** differ: Cārvāka must explain how matter yields subjectivity; Buddhism must explain how an ownerless stream yields memory, desert and liberation.

⚠ **Verdict:** Cārvāka denies the self's **transcendence** while retaining its **substantiality**; Buddhism denies its substantiality while retaining its **moral continuity**.

Depth refinement. Both views face continuity problems of different kinds: Cārvāka must explain identity through bodily change without a separate subject; Buddhism must explain responsibility across an ownerless causal series. This symmetry prevents a one-sided comparison.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2024 Q6(a): the twenty-mark demand is *differentiate*, so the two denials must be shown to be different in kind. The decisive line is that material form is itself an aggregate declared not-self.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: define both denials; four axes of difference; the aggregate argument; the Puggalavāda foil in one clause; a conclusion that refuses to treat them as species of one genus.

- **Structure:** the two positions stated compactly → four explicit differentiating theses → a one-line verdict. Do not write two biographies.
- **Doctrine:** *conscious body as self* (*dehātmavāda*) with the Sanskrit formula; the five *skandhas* named in order; *santāna*; *pratītyasamutpāda* and *kṣaṇikavāda*.
- **Argument:** the "I am fat / lame / blind" argument, and the chariot analogy, both reproduced.
- **Distinction:** transcendence versus substantiality — this single distinction carries the whole answer.
- **Technical terms:** *caitanya-viśiṣṭaḥ kāyaḥ puruṣaḥ*, *anātman* / *nairātmyavāda*, *pudgala-nairātmya*, *ālaya-viññāna*, *bīja*.
- **Criticism:** the point that *rūpa* is itself a *skandha*, so Buddhism rules out the Cārvāka self explicitly — very few candidates make it.

2025 · Q5(a) · 10 marks

Question: Explain the ground on which Cārvāka rejects inference as a valid source of knowledge.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Explain the ground</i> — a focused, architecturally clean exposition; evaluation is secondary
Core issue	The impossibility of establishing <i>invariable concomitance</i> (<i>vyāpti</i>)
Scope boundary	Stay on the ground for rejection; do not survey the other schools' replies at length
Ideal thesis	The ground is that <i>invariable concomitance</i> (<i>vyāpti</i>), without which inference cannot claim certainty, is unobtainable by any means the Cārvāka admits
Non-negotiables	<i>Invariable concomitance</i> (<i>vyāpti</i>) defined; the three doors; <i>hidden limiting condition</i> (<i>upādhi</i>); the "accident and separable" line; one closing sentence of balance

Independent model answer

✓ The ground is the **impossibility of establishing invariable concomitance (vyāpti)**. Inference moves from a perceived mark to an unperceived *sādhya*, and is licensed only by an invariable concomitance — "wherever smoke, there fire". For inference to be a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*), that universal must be beyond doubt.

It cannot be had by perception: we cannot perceive all cases of smoke and fire even now, "to speak nothing of those which existed in the past or will exist in the future"; and the retreat to class-characters fails, since "smokeness" itself is not perceptually known while all instances are not perceived.

Nor by inference: that would be a *petitio principii*, since the further inference needs its own *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*).

Nor by testimony: testimony's own validity is inferred; and if inference depended on it, "no one could infer anything by himself."

Hidden limiting condition (upādhi) completes the case: fire yields smoke only where fuel is wet, and hidden conditions "may always remain hidden and escape notice", so unconditionality is never certified.

⚠ Hence truth is "only an **accident**, and a **separable** one" in inference — not the guaranteed character a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*) requires.

Depth refinement. The strongest soft reading permits corrigible, perception-redeemable practical expectation. It protects ordinary life but transforms the dispute into one about certainty, scope and transcendental overreach.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2025 Q5(a): the directive is *explain the ground*, so the three doors are the answer and the Nyāya reply is not asked for. Give it at most one clause.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: define invariable concomitance; three doors, visibly three; the hidden condition in one line; close on the accidental-truth point rather than on evaluation.

- **Structure:** define *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* → three doors → *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* → the "accident and separable" conclusion. Clean, fast, complete.
- **Doctrine:** *invariable concomitance (vyāpti)*, *liṅga* and *sādhya*, *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)*, *petitio principii*.
- **Argument:** the three doors must be visibly three; a vague "it cannot be proved" earns little.
- **Distinction:** rejection as *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)* versus everyday expectation — one clause is enough, but it must be there.
- **Technical terms:** at least four Sanskrit terms, each glossed on first use.
- **Comparison:** at most one clause on Nyāya's reply; the question does not ask for it.

2022 · Q7(c) · 15 marks — supporting routed question, primary owner Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika

Question: How do Naiyāyikas respond to Cārvāka's objections against inference (anumāna) and establish inference as an independent means of knowledge? Critically discuss.

Practice status and source caution: This is an independent learner model, not an official UPSC key. The question is owned primarily by Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika and is reproduced here because it tests the Cārvāka objections from the other side; the Cārvāka half must therefore be stated accurately and then answered, not caricatured.

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically discuss</i> — reconstruct the Nyāya reply and then judge whether it succeeds
Limb 1	How do they respond? — the specific devices, named, not a general appeal to reason
Limb 2	How is independence established? — inference must not reduce to perception or testimony
Limb 3	Critical judgement — what the reply achieves and what it concedes
Scope boundary	Stay on inference; do not drift into the Nyāya proofs of God or the category scheme
Ideal thesis	Nyāya succeeds by changing the standard from omniscient certainty to disciplined warrant, which answers the Cārvāka's conclusion while conceding his logical premise
Non-negotiables	<i>Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)</i> ; positive and negative correlation; elimination of the <i>hidden limiting condition (upādhi)</i> ; <i>hypothetical reasoning (tarka)</i> ; <i>parāmarśa</i> ; the self-refutation counter-charge; one honest limitation

Independent model answer

The objection to be met. ✅ The Cārvāka holds that inference (*anumāna*) is not an independent means of valid knowledge because its indispensable universal, *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*), cannot be established: not by perception, which surveys only finite cases; not by inference, which would need a further *vyāpti* and so runs into circularity or regress; and not by testimony, whose own validity is unproved. The *hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*) sharpens this, since what looked like a bare universal may all along have been conditioned — fire yields smoke only with wet fuel.

The Nyāya response. ✅ The Naiyāyika abandons the demand for an omniscient survey and builds *vyāpti* instead from **agreement in presence** (*anvaya*), **agreement in absence** (*vyatireka*), **the systematic elimination of suspected upādhis**, and **hypothetical reasoning** (*tarka*), which shows that denying the relation makes experience incoherent. Later Nyāya adds *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*, so the relation is grasped between class-characters rather than tallied instance by instance.

Why inference is then independent. ⚠️ Independence rests on *parāmarśa*, the mark cognised **as qualified by** the concomitance. That composite cognition is neither a fresh perception of fire nor a speaker's report, so inference is irreducible to perception or testimony.

Critical assessment. ⚠️ The reply works by redefinition rather than refutation. Nyāya concedes that finite observation cannot *entail* an unrestricted universal and denies only the epistemological conclusion, since warrant does not require entailment. Three residues remain: *tarka* is not itself a means of valid knowledge; *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* presupposes Nyāya realism about universals; and elimination removes only *suspected* conditions.

⚠️ **Verdict:** the Naiyāyika defeats the strong thesis, since a universal denial of inference cannot itself be perceived and other minds are never perceived either. He does not restore certainty; he substitutes disciplined, defeasible warrant — the fallibilist position a refined Cārvāka could accept.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — 2022 Q7(c): the answer must be visibly two-sided. State the Cārvāka objection in its three-door form before replying, name each Nyāya device separately, and prove independence through *parāmarśa* rather than by asserting it.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: objection in three lines; four named devices in one dense paragraph; independence in two lines; one paragraph of honest residue; a one-sentence verdict that distinguishes warrant from certainty.

- **Structure:** objection → four devices → the independence argument → three residues → graded verdict.
- **Doctrine:** *vyāpti*, *anvaya*, *vyatireka*, *upādhi*, *tarka*, *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa*, *parāmarśa*.
- **Argument:** the independence limb is the one most candidates omit; without *parāmarśa* the answer only defends reliability, not independence.
- **Distinction:** entailment versus warrant — say it explicitly, because it identifies the true locus of the dispute.
- **Criticism:** at least two of the three residues must appear, or the answer reads as partisan.
- **Cross-link:** this is the mirror image of the 2018 and 2025 Cārvāka questions; the same material answers all three from different sides.

These six questions are original practice prompts, not UPSC PYQs. Each model is written independently for learner use.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why the Cārvāka rejects *verbal testimony* (*śabda*) as an independent *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*), and assess whether the rejection is consistent with his acceptance of perception. **(10 marks, about 150 to 200 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Explain</i> then <i>assess</i> — exposition plus a consistency verdict
Core issue	Whether admitting words-as-sounds while refusing words-as-evidence is coherent
Ideal thesis	The rejection is internally consistent, since the perceived item is the sound and the disputed item is the content

Full independent model answer

✓ The Cārvāka argument runs in steps. Words heard through the ears are **perceived**, so knowledge of words is perceptual and valid. But insofar as words "suggest or mean things not within our perception", they "are not free from error and doubt". Acceptance of an authority proceeds through a suppressed inference — "this authority is reliable; all reliable authority should be accepted" — and, being based on inference, testimony is "as precarious as inference". In the special case of the Veda, claims of authority cannot be perceptually certified, and Chatterjee and Datta report the Cārvāka's charge that the texts are "the works of some cunning priests".

⚠ **Assessment.** The rejection is consistent, because the Cārvāka carefully separates two objects: the **sound**, which is perceived, and the **content**, which is not. He therefore denies testimony independent *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*)-status without denying communication. The residual cost is that a life without testimonial knowledge is unliveable — but that is a charge of impracticality, not of inconsistency.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — Original 1: the consistency verdict depends on one distinction — the perceived sound against the unperceived content. State it explicitly, or the assessment collapses into assertion.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: the five-step argument compressed to four lines; the sound-content distinction; the suppressed reliability premise; a verdict separating inconsistency from impracticality.

- The five-step argument reproduced, not merely summarised.
- The sound/content distinction stated explicitly — this is what secures consistency.
- The suppressed reliability premise identified as an **inference**.

- One line on the Veda, framed epistemically rather than as abuse.
- A verdict that distinguishes **inconsistency** from **impracticality**.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish *explanation through natural properties* (*svabhāvavāda*) from *yadṛcchāvāda* in Cārvāka metaphysics and examine whether they are consistent. **(10 marks, about 150 to 200 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Distinguish</i> then <i>examine</i> consistency — a conceptual distinction put to critical work
Core issue	Whether fixed natures and fortuitous combination can both be asserted
Ideal thesis	They are compatible only if <i>svabhāva</i> governs the behaviour of elements while <i>yadṛcchā</i> governs their initial concurrence ; otherwise there is tension

Full independent model answer

✓ **Explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)** is naturalism: "the material elements themselves have got each its fixed nature (*svabhāva*)", and it is by these inherent natures and laws that they combine, so "there is thus no necessity for God"; fire is hot and water cool by their own natures. ✓ **Yadṛcchāvāda** is mechanism or accidentalism: it "denies the existence of conscious purpose behind the world" and explains it "as a mere mechanical or **fortuitous** combination of elements".

⚠ **Examination.** There is a real tension. If the elements combine **by their fixed natures**, the resulting world is lawful and not fortuitous; if the combination is **fortuitous**, natures cannot be doing the explanatory work. The most charitable reconstruction assigns them different roles: *svabhāva* explains how each element **behaves** once in combination, while *yadṛcchā* denies that any **purpose** governs which combinations occur. On that reading they are consistent, and their joint target is teleology rather than regularity. ⚠ The Cārvāka's own caution supports this: he grants that there is "neither any guarantee that uniformity perceived in the past would continue in future".

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — Original 2: the marks lie in refusing to merge the two doctrines. Own-nature explanation preserves regularity; accidentalism destroys it, and its attribution to the school must be flagged as contested.

Exam-length execution — 10 marks, about 150 to 200 words: define both; one named illustration each; the consistency verdict; one line on why the contested attribution matters for what may safely be written.

- Both terms defined with the textbook's own glosses.
- The tension named explicitly rather than glossed over.
- A charitable reconstruction offered, with its division of labour.

- The "no guarantee of future uniformity" line used as evidence for the deflationary reading.
- A verdict that identifies **teleology**, not regularity, as the common target.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Examine the Cārvāka doctrine that consciousness is an emergent by-product of the four elements, with the objections it faces. **(15 marks, about 250 to 300 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Examine ... with the objections</i> — exposition plus a serious objection set and replies
Core issue	Whether the emergence analogies establish emergence of the right logical type
Ideal thesis	The analogies establish that novel public qualities emerge; consciousness is private and first-personal, so the explanatory gap remains — though dualism does not close it either

Full independent model answer

✓ **The doctrine.** *Kiṇvāḍibhyo madaśaktivad vijñānam*: consciousness arises from matter as intoxicating power arises from fermenting agents. The objection it answers is stated by Chatterjee and Datta: "we do not perceive consciousness in any of the four material elements. How can it then come to qualify their product, the body?" The reply uses two analogies with distinct functions. **Betel** — leaf, lime and nut, "none of which is originally red", yielding a reddish tinge when chewed together — establishes **compositional** emergence. **Fermentation** — molasses, "originally non-intoxicant", becoming intoxicant when allowed to ferment — establishes **transformational** emergence. Consciousness is accordingly "an **epiphenomenon** or by-product of matter".

⚠ **Objections.** (i) The analogies concern **public, third-person** qualities; consciousness is **private** — Sharma notes it "is neither smelt nor tasted nor seen nor touched nor heard", and "consciousness of an individual cannot be shared by others". (ii) In swoon, epilepsy and dreamless sleep the living body persists **without** consciousness, so the property is not inseparable. (iii) Constant co-occurrence is not causation: "the eye cannot see in darkness ... yet light cannot be regarded as the cause of sight", and the two horns of a bull are conjoined without being causally related — so the body may be the **instrument** of consciousness rather than its cause.

⚠ **Replies and verdict.** The Cārvāka may answer that the property is essential to a specific **organisation** rather than to bare bodily existence, and that positing an immaterial soul merely **renames** the gap. The honest verdict: the evidence establishes **dependence**, not production; both sides face the gap, and only one claims to have crossed it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — Original 3: state the emergence claim precisely before objecting to it, and keep the two analogies doing different work — one compositional, one transformational — rather than treating them as interchangeable.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: the claim in three lines; both analogies with their distinct roles; the bearer objection and the explanatory-gap objection; a verdict that concedes what emergence does not explain.

- The transmitted *sūtra* quoted or paraphrased.
- Both analogies, with their **distinct** functions named.
- The word *epiphenomenon* used precisely.
- At least three objections, at least two of them from the standard battery.
- The Cārvāka's replies given before the verdict.
- A verdict distinguishing **dependence** from **production**.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The Cārvāka's *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* objection is a stronger argument than his objection from incomplete enumeration." Critically discuss. **(15 marks, about 250 to 300 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically discuss</i> an evaluative comparison between two of the Cārvāka's own arguments
Core issue	Sample size versus identification of the relevant variable
Ideal thesis	The claim is correct: enumeration is curable in principle by more observation, whereas <i>hidden limiting condition (upādhi)</i> is not

Full independent model answer

✓ **The enumeration objection.** *Invariable concomitance (vyāpti)* requires knowledge of all cases, and "we cannot perceive even all the cases of smoke and fire existing now ... to speak nothing of those which existed in the past or will exist in the future".

✓ **The *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* objection.** Even where two things are repeatedly observed together, an unnoticed condition may be operating. One who has often seen fire accompanied by smoke may infer smoke from fire and err, having failed to notice the *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* of **wetness of fuel**, on whose presence alone fire is attended with smoke. Hence "so long as the relation between two phenomena is not proved to be **unconditional**, it is an uncertain ground for inference" — and unconditionality "cannot be established beyond doubt by perception, as some conditions may **always remain hidden**".

⚠ **Why the second is stronger.** Enumeration is a defect of **quantity**: more observation improves the position, even if it never completes it. *Hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* is a defect of **identification**: it concerns whether the property picked out is the genuine ground of the relation, and no amount of further counting settles it. The proof is dialectical — Nyāya answers enumeration with *bhūyodarśana* and the joint

method of co-presence and co-absence, but must bring in **hypothetical reasoning (tarka)** and *sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa* to address *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)*, and concedes that only **suspected** conditions can be eliminated.

⚠ **Counter-consideration and verdict.** Nyāya may reply that a relation surviving systematic negative-case testing plus *hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* is rationally warranted even if not indefeasible. That defends inference; it does not refute the *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* point. The claim therefore stands: *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* is the deeper argument, and it is the one that forces Nyāya to change the standard from certainty to warrant.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — Original 4: the comparison is the answer. Show that incomplete enumeration is quantitative and can in principle be reduced, while the hidden condition is structural and survives any amount of observation.

Exam-length execution — 15 marks, about 250 to 300 words: define both objections; the structural-versus-quantitative contrast; the Nyāya elimination reply; the residue that elimination removes only suspected conditions; a verdict.

- Both objections stated accurately, with the *hidden limiting condition (upādhi)* example running **fire** → **smoke**.
- The quantity/identification distinction stated as the pivot of the answer.
- The dialectical proof: Nyāya's differential response to the two objections.
- *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* correctly described as an auxiliary, not a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*.
- A verdict that concedes Nyāya's warrant-based defence while upholding the comparison.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Cārvāka's metaphysics is nothing but its epistemology written out as a list of denials." Critically evaluate. **(20 marks, about 340 to 400 words)**

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Critically evaluate</i> a strong interpretive claim — say how far it is true and where it fails
Core issue	Whether the metaphysics is wholly derivative or contains independent positive commitments
Ideal thesis	Largely true of the denials , false of the affirmations — the four elements, emergence and <i>svabhāva</i> are positive theses not entailed by the epistemology alone

Full independent model answer

✓ **The case for the claim.** Chatterjee and Datta state that the Cārvāka theory of reality "**follows from**" the epistemological conclusion: if perception is the only reliable source of knowledge, "we can rationally assert only the reality of perceptible objects. God, soul, heaven, life before birth or after death, and any unperceived law (like *adr̥ṣṭa*) cannot be believed in, because they are all beyond perception."

The derivation is exact. *Ākāśa* falls because it is inferred from sound. *Enduring self (ātman)* falls because no soul is perceived apart from the living body. *Lord (Īśvara)* falls because he is reached only by design-inference. *Action and moral consequence (karma)*, *adr̥ṣṭa*, rebirth, *svarga* and *liberation (mokṣa)* fall as unseen forces or post-mortem states. Vedic authority falls with *verbal testimony (śabda)*, and ritual with it. One cut, seven casualties.

⚠ **Where the claim fails.** Three points. (i) The derivation needs a **bridging principle** — that ontological commitment must not outrun the accepted *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas)* — which is a **presupposition**, not a theorem. An opponent could accept the epistemology and hold that reality exceeds knowledge; the Cārvāka's refusal of that gap is a substantive metaphysical decision.

(ii) The metaphysics contains **positive** theses the epistemology does not yield. That there are exactly **four** elements, that they are **eternal** while their combinations perish, that consciousness **emerges** from organised matter as redness emerges from betel and intoxication from fermented molasses, and that *svabhāva* explains regularity — none of these is entailed by "only perception is a *means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa)*". They are empirical and explanatory hypotheses.

(iii) There is even an internal strain among them: *explanation through natural properties (svabhāvavāda)* grounds regularity in fixed natures while *yadr̥cchāvāda* calls the world's objects "fortuitous products". A purely derivative metaphysics could not generate such a tension.

⚠ **Verdict.** The claim is **true of the negative half and false of the positive half**. Cārvāka's denials are indeed epistemology written out as a list — which is why they stand or fall entirely with the rejection of inference. But its affirmations are a materialist research programme in miniature, and they carry explanatory burdens of their own: chiefly the explanatory gap between public emergent qualities and private consciousness, which no epistemic restriction can discharge. ⚠ Criterion named: **derivational economy** supports the claim, **explanatory content** refutes it.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — Original 5: the quotation must be tested, not illustrated. Show the derivation working, then find the point at which the metaphysics adds something the epistemology alone does not license.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: the derivation in four denials; two places where the ontology outruns the criterion; the strongest objection with a reply; a graded verdict on the quotation itself.

- The derivation reproduced compactly, with connectives.
- The bridging principle named as a **presupposition**.
- At least three positive theses identified as underivable from the epistemology.
- The internal *svabhāva* / *yadr̥cchā* tension used as evidence.
- A split verdict — true of the denials, false of the affirmations — with a named criterion.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the Cārvāka and Nyāya positions on *invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*), and assess whether Nyāya successfully answers the Cārvāka. (20 marks, about 340 to 400 words)

Demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Directive	<i>Compare</i> then <i>assess success</i> — the assessment must name a standard of success
Core issue	Whether replacing certainty with warrant answers the objection or changes the subject
Ideal thesis	Nyāya succeeds against the practical challenge and concedes the logical point; the dispute is ultimately about the concept of knowledge

Full independent model answer

✓ **Cārvāka.** *Invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*) is required for inference to claim certainty, and it can be had from no admitted source. Not from perception: all cases past, present and future are never surveyed, and the retreat to class-characters fails, since "smokeness" itself is not perceptually known. Not from inference: *petitio principii* or regress; deduction is circular and induction unwarranted. Not from testimony: its own validity is inferred, and if inference depended on it "no one could infer anything by himself". *Hidden limiting condition* (*upādhi*) completes the case, since unconditionality cannot be certified while hidden conditions "may always remain hidden and escape notice".

✓ **Nyāya.** *Invariable concomitance* (*vyāpti*) is **assembled**, not intuited in one act. Repeated observation (*bhūyodarśana*) is disciplined as **agreement in presence (anvaya)** (co-presence) and **agreement in absence (vyatireka)** (co-absence), making it a structured search for counter-instances. Suspected *upādhis* are identified and the universal restated at the correct level — "fire joined with wet fuel, there smoke". **Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)** — not a *means of valid knowledge* (*pramāṇa*) but a *pramāṇa-anugrāhaka* — assumes the contradictory and exhibits an unacceptable consequence, removing the doubt that blocks *vyāptigraha*. **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa-pratyakṣa** answers the class-character objection by presenting the universal through the particular. Finally, **parāmarśa** — the mark cognised as qualified by concomitance — shows that no "leap" occurs at all.

⚠ **Assessment.** Nyāya succeeds on three counts. *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* has real bite against Cārvāka specifically, since the Cārvāka's own acting, expecting and arguing presuppose the regularities he refuses to certify. *Parāmarśa* dissolves the "leap" picture on which the objection trades. And Sharma's counter-attack reverses the hierarchy: perception errs — the flat earth, the static earth, the small solar disc — and is corrected **by inference**, while "mere sensation cannot be regarded as a means of knowledge unless conception ... has arranged into order ... the loose threads of sense-data".

⚠ Yet three concessions remain. Only **suspected upādhis** can be eliminated. *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* proves nothing alone. *Sāmānyalakṣaṇa* is defensible only inside Nyāya's realism about universals.

⚠ **Verdict.** Nyāya answers the Cārvāka **by changing the standard** — from omniscient certainty to disciplined rational warrant, since "the Nyāya point is not infallibilism but disciplined justificatory practice". Judged by **warrant**, Nyāya wins; judged by **entailment**, the Cārvāka's logical point survives untouched. The real disagreement is therefore about the concept of knowledge, not about the logic of induction, on which both agree.

Why this earns marks

Answer-writing focus — Original 6: the assessment limb decides the grade. Show that both sides agree finite observation cannot entail a universal, so the dispute is about the concept of knowledge, not about induction.

Exam-length execution — 20 marks, about 340 to 400 words: the Cārvāka case; four Nyāya devices; the entailment-versus-warrant diagnosis; three honest residues against Nyāya; a verdict naming its criterion.

- Both positions given their strongest form, with Sanskrit terms glossed.
- The eight-stage Nyāya construction at least summarised.
- *Hypothetical reasoning (tarka)* and *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* correctly characterised, including their limits.
- Sharma's counter-attack on perception included.
- A verdict that names **two** criteria and delivers a different result under each.